

Deadlines and Background for Departmental Honors in Physics

January 8/January 14 2026



3:30 - 4:20pm Thursday Honors Class

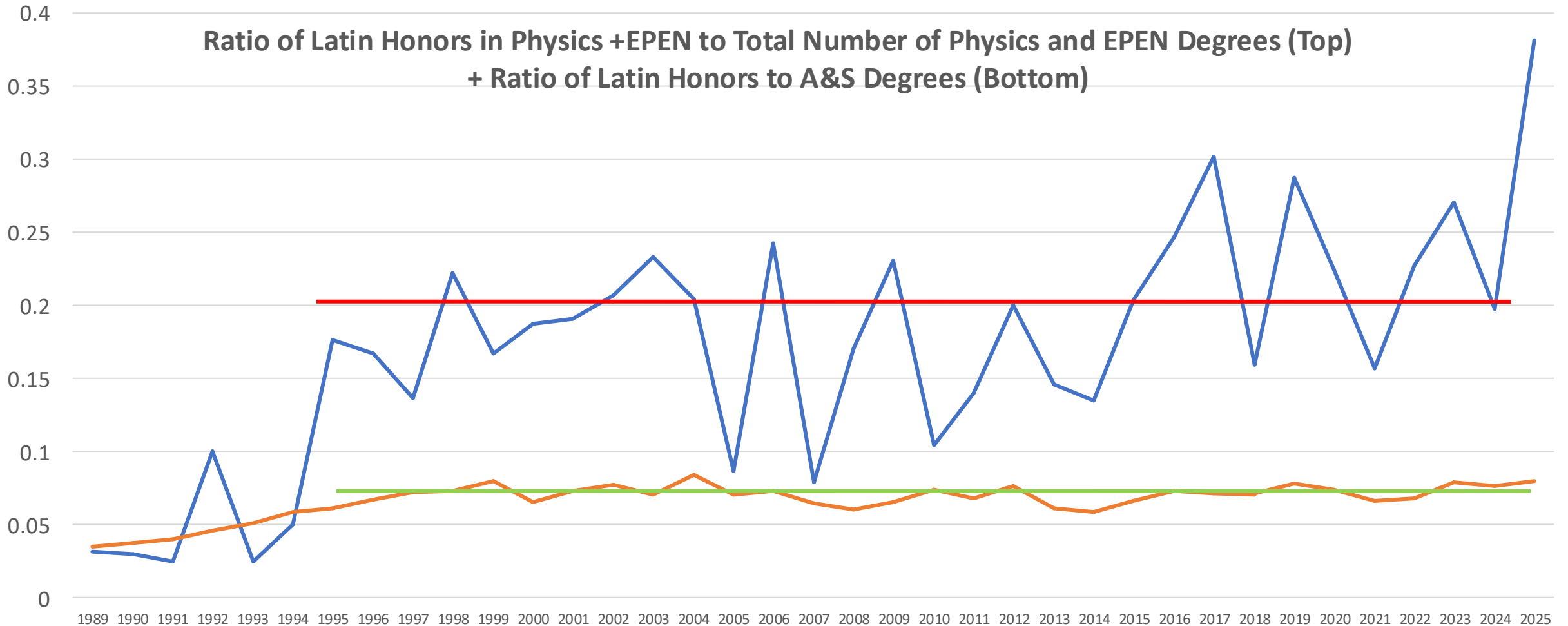
Person	Advisor	Honors Class	When Expect to Graduate
Ted Applebaum	Yuan Shi	4620	Spring 2026
Jamison Barcelona	Ethan Neil	4620	Spring 2026
Amelia Gandhi	Nick Schneider (APS)	4620	Spring 2026
Mason Hergert	Xun Gao	4620	Spring 2026
Zachary Janota	Paul Beale	4620	Spring 2026
Ashton Kozloski	John Bohn	4620	Spring 2026
Gilbert Lopez	Nick Schneider (APS)	4620	Spring 2026
Aaron Price	Heather Lewandowski	4630	Spring 2026
Arabella Quane	Gang Cao	4620	Spring 2026
Finnegan Thompson	Markus Raschke	4620	Spring 2026
Megan Thompson	Judah Levine	4620	Spring 2026
Thomas Williams	Jan Deca	4620	Spring 2026
Ruomu Zhang	Cindy Regal	4630	Spring 2026

2:30 – 3:20pm Wednesday Honors Class

Person	Advisor	Honors Class	When Expect to Graduate
Owen Allison	Xun Gao	4630	Spring 2026
Ray Anchordoquy	Juliet Gopinath	4620	Spring 2026
Ben Braun	Michael Litos	4630	Spring 2026
Austin Campbell	Juliet Gopinath	4620	Spring 2026
Agua Chung	Xun Gao	4630	Spring 2026
Tess Ekblad	Thomas Schibli	4630	Spring 2026
Angel Gomez	Ed Thiemann (LASP)	4620	Spring 2026
Samuel Hagele	Yuan Shi	4620	Spring 2026
Aidan McCready	David Nesbitt	4620	Spring 2026
Christian Ordetx	Murray Holland	4630	Spring 2026
Joey Pontiff	Thomas Schibli	4630	Spring 2026
Joelle Pospisil	Alysia Marino	4630	Spring 2026
Jack Ulmer	Melina Piket-May (ECEE)	4630	Spring 2026

7% of A&S students graduate with honors, but
20% of Physics students now graduate with honors

Ratio of Latin Honors in Physics +EPEN to Total Number of Physics and EPEN Degrees (Top)
+ Ratio of Latin Honors to A&S Degrees (Bottom)



Overview

Honors Students (37)– sections can be a mix of 4610, 4620 and 4630 students.

3 sections

- a) Wednesday (13) 2:30 – 3:20 pm John Cumalat (11th floor Reading Room)
- b) Thursday (11) 2:00 – 2:50 pm John Cumalat (11th floor Reading Room)
- c) Thursday (13) 3:30 – 4:20 pm John Cumalat (11th floor Reading Room)

Tobin Munsat will fill in for meetings as needed

<https://www.colorado.edu/honors/> (note: you need to click on “Honors Thesis” and look at links on the right hand side.) You can obtain older theses since 2012 from this page. (*How to view older Honors Theses*)

This course will help prepare you for your thesis defense, and to some degree writing your thesis as well.

Honors Webpage <https://www.colorado.edu/honors/graduation>

Thesis Resources

- [Registration forms and deadlines](#)
- [Honors Thesis - Getting Started](#) handout
- [Honors Council Representatives](#)
- [Thesis Defense Form for Faculty](#) (standard version)
- [Thesis Defense Form for Faculty](#) (electronic fillable version)
- [Thesis Information for Faculty](#)
- [Undergraduate Honors Theses Repository on CU Scholar](#)
- [How to view previous Honors Theses](#)
- [The Writing Center](#)
- [ALA Fair Use Evaluator](#)
- [Fair Use Checklist \(Columbia University\)](#)
- [Publisher copyright policies: SHERPA/RoMEO](#)
- [CU Experts \(research and expertise discovery search tool\)](#)
- [Undergraduate Research Opportunities Program](#)
- [Honors Thesis Symposium](#)
- [Frequently Asked Questions](#)
- [Honors Convocation](#)



Defending Spring 2026 (this semester)

April 1, 2026: Last day to defend AND defense copy due by 11:59pm

- The defense copy is the version of the thesis you defended in front of your committee. This is the version that we will use for consideration of Latin honors.
- Your title page must include your name, department, thesis title, and defense date as well as the names and departments of each of your committee members, with the thesis advisor specified.
- You will be required to submit an electronic copy in PDF format using this link by 11:59pm.
- This is also the last day to defend for this semester. If you defend prior to April 1st, please submit your defense copy at that time.

April 7, 2026: Final copy due on CU Scholar by 11:59pm

- During your defense, your committee might suggest changes to your thesis. You have until April 7th to make any changes you wish. These changes will not be considered when determining your Latin honors designation.
- **On or before April 7th**, upload the final copy of your thesis to the Undergraduate Honors Thesis repository on CU Scholar. For details visit <https://www.colorado.edu/honors/graduation/cuscholar>
- If you need to make changes to your uploaded thesis, you will need to contact the CU Scholar Admin at cuscholaradmin@colorado.edu. Theses will be approved and posted to CU Scholar within four weeks.

Getting Ready for the Defense

- Need to fix your defense time with your committee members.

Constraints are: Spring break – March 16-20

Must be defended by April 1

Make sure you schedule a room with Main Office (Maria Martinez)

Work backwards and figure out when you should be done to give the committee several days to read the thesis. Typically a week

Try to do a practice talk in your group in addition to the class

How is the level of honors decided?

GPA + Thesis Work

- There are GPA requirements, but grades are only one part of the decision process.
- A minimum cumulative GPA of 3.3 qualifies a student to be considered for honors, *cum laude*;
- A minimum cumulative GPA of 3.5 qualifies a student to be considered for honors, *magna cum laude*;
- A minimum cumulative GPA of 3.8 qualifies a student to be considered for honors, *summa cum laude*.
- While these guidelines qualify a student for consideration for a given level of honors, the honors earned are also based on the quality of the thesis and thesis defense. Depending on the quality of the thesis and thesis defense, a defense committee may recommend an honors designation other than what the guidelines suggest.

Additional Thesis Information Assessment

Key ingredients:

What is basis for the thesis and how was the basis defended or addressed? Why is the topic important to physics/discipline?

How was the defense presentation and how was the student at answering questions?

How is quality of the written document?

Are there any publications that include the student's name?

Has the student made other presentations at conferences or at meetings outside of CU?

What is the level of the work? Is it at the level of graduate work?

What will we do during our meeting times?

The course time is devoted principally to student presentations of their research, including follow-up Q&A's from other students and the Prof.

For the next 9 weeks we will have 2 speakers per week with each talk 20 + 5 minutes per week. We will start next week.

~ 2 students will be assigned as a peer reviewer for each speaker, with the reviews to be returned anonymously to the speakers

Presentation Reviews -

- Clarity of Material
- Slide Quality
- Oral Communication Quality
- Ability to Answer Questions
- Excitement Level
- Is material presented at right level?
- Was sufficient background material provided

Making a Poster

- Going to require everyone to make a poster
- We have purchased a department poster printer so it shouldn't cost you anything. Expectation is the poster printer will be available for use in about 1 month.
- Should be useful for conference sessions
- We are thinking of highlighting these poster at future events, perhaps graduation, job fairs, etc.

Advice and Expectations

- Expectation is that you work an average of 8-10 hours per week on your research project.
- Keep a log book – good if it is paper, but can be electronic -best if you can go back and recover your calculations, how you made a sample, note difficulties and how you overcame them, record where you bought equipment, etc.
- Start compiling a list of references
- Take lots of pictures of your lab setup.

AI – Artificial Intelligence + Honor Code

Dear Honors Council Representatives,

- The Honors Program is currently carrying out research to create a formal policy regarding the use of AI in writing or editing one's Honors undergraduate thesis. **In the meantime, our current policy is that AI *may not be used in the writing, re-writing, or editing of an undergraduate Honors thesis.***
- A student using generative AI to help write, edit, and/or rewrite their thesis is no longer the sole author. A requirement of writing an Honors thesis is that the student be the sole author of the work. Since a student who is the sole author cannot credit other authors (such as ChatGPT), using generative AI would be considered plagiarism, which is a violation of the Honor Code. We do permit students to incorporate feedback and suggested edits by their committee members.
- We will be providing this information to our Spring 2026 thesis students via our Honors Student Center Canvas Community page, but you are also welcome to share this email with your thesis students, as well as your students' other committee members. We will be in touch again once we've created a formal policy. If students or faculty have questions about this, please contact honors@colorado.edu.

Backup Information